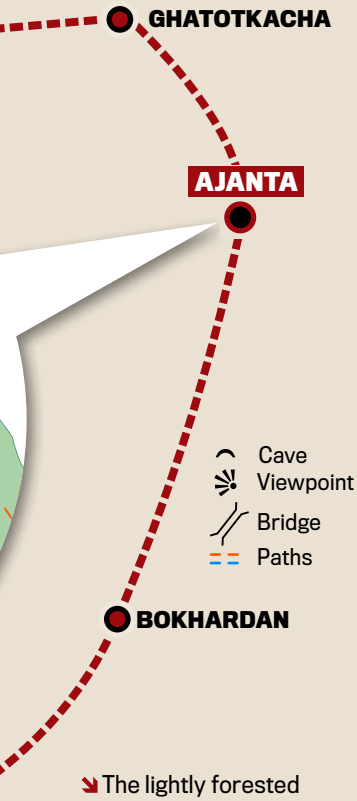
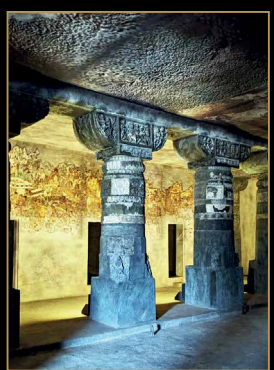


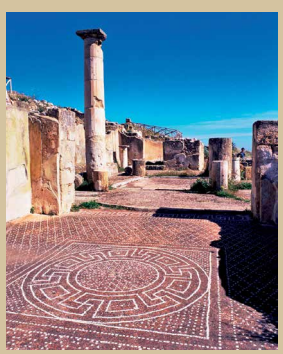
- The lightly forested Inhyadri range offers good scope for nature tourism—Ajanta has rich bird life, with 152 species listed on ebird.org; Banoti needs an adventurous trek
- Reopen the Visitor Centre, with attractive programme calendars for tourists, scholars, schoolchildren (a big chunk of the crowds)
- Develop the other side of the river (now under the forest department) as a resting, refreshment and ambulatory zone—run by locals—to help diffuse crowds

Replica at Ajanta VC 6



NEW WAYS FORWARD

- India's conservation science must move beyond 20th-c practices like chemical treatment. Heritage- and eco-friendly biological interventions are throwing up fascinating possibilities worldwide. On the floor mosaic at the Greco-Roman site of Soluntum, Sicily (below), essential oils of oregano and thyme have worked



- Institutions like CSIR-NEERI must circulate their site-specific scientific findings freely, enabling quick translational interventions and a constantly updated pool of conservators. Adopt an open access approach; India occupies the other extreme—bureaucratic silo behaviour
- Research is a big vacuum in India—we have only a fistful of site experts for one of the world's most important Buddhist sites. "At Mogao, China, has 300 researchers on site all the time, studying everything from geology to archaeology," says conservationist Sanjay Dhar
- Serious study of the sociology of tourism (e.g. demarcating those who seek 'authenticity' from casual tourists) informs policies in the West. We must formalise insights on our unique patterns—like class, or 'romantic couples' being a serious category at heritage sites

RSOUV a decade ago; the WHC adopted it only in 2021. Barring the six-yearly period reviews, the last full State of Conservation report was submitted to the WHC in 2002. The gaps in between are where the mortar fell off.

AN URGENT NEED FOR ACTION

The main dilemma is how to think of footfalls: an inherent good, or a bane? Peril often produces the extreme reaction—the clanging down of shutters. And those who lean towards nonchalant overtourism risk getting chastised—Peru got multiple warnings from Unesco for Machu Pichu. It may seem counter-intuitive to propose Ajanta as a hub to solve a problem of numbers (see the blueprint in *How to Save Ajanta*), but an integrated zonal plan with a special, multilateral monitoring body composed of experts drawn from all sides marries several imperatives. "Rock-cut caves are a special component of Indian architectural history, and need long-term monitoring and vision," says Dhumal, who is preparing a site plan for the Jogeshwari Caves in Mumbai.

At present, Ajanta's prize status scarcely touches anything. The local economy is an immiserated landscape standing in sullen aloofness from it. The rich ecosystem of rock-cut Buddhist cave sites that radiate out from it stay in neglect—the JICA documents often rue this fact, especially referencing the spectacular site of Pitalkhora. A collective status, then? "A case can clearly be made as there is obvious Outstanding Universal Value, and there's a trend towards promotion of historic landscapes," says conservator Richard Hughes, former president of ICOMOS Britain. There's also a gulf between the ASI, which often treats its trusteeship of heritage with a proprietorial air, and many of India's most adept conservators, who consequently never get to work on Ajanta. "The ASI system is such that someone untrained in mural conservation could be in charge of Ajanta tomorrow, and a lot of their work is outsourced to contractors," says Dhar. He also touches on a topic that only gets whispered about—"there's been a lot of retouching of the murals by its inhouse artists".

Oversight is painful, but necessary. A big tent is also a healthier place than a silo for the ASI's own talent pool—as an extension, former director-general Gautam Sengupta, who mandated the NEERI studies during his tenure, bats for "greater autonomy" for the ASI itself. Ajanta as a case-study can put the whole system under an X-Ray Fluorescence machine. But what it reveals in its deepest layers is the organic decay in our very relationship with heritage—surface showmanship, emptied of real engagement. As Rajesh Singh says, "We need a base of hundreds of dedicated scholars studying Ajanta. I have been here for 30 years, and feel I've only begun." Reimagining Ajanta in toto could be a beginning, then. Far from what Buddhabhadra feared: an ending in crepuscular light. ■